OTT

A Tragedy Retold



Prashant Nair's latest Netflix series, *Trial By Fire*, is a bold recap of the 1997 Uphaar cinema fire and a grieving couple's struggle for justice



"There's no word in our language for a parent who has lost kids," says writer-director Prashant Nair, whose credits include *Made in Heaven* (2019–) and *Tryst with Destiny* (2021). The protagonists of Nair's latest Netflix series, *Trial By Fire*, are Neelam and Shekhar Krishnamoorthy, who lost their kids—a son and a daughter—in the deadly Uphaar cinema fire in Delhi in 1997. Based on the duo's 2016 book, the Netflix series stars Abhay Deol and Rajshri Deshpande as the grieving couple who embark on a mission to hold the owners, the Ansal brothers, Sushil and Gopal, accountable for the tragedy that left 59 dead and 103 injured.

Like season one of *Delhi Crime* (2019–), *Trial By Fire* may be classified as a lest-we-forget, hard-hitting drama. That the accident occurred in a cinema, a recreational space, evokes an eerie sense that it could happen to anyone. By revisiting the event, the seven-episode series shows how difficult it is for those affected to move on; it also exposes the public safety violations and negligence by the management. Where the show differs from *Delhi Crime* is that it can name all those who were ultimately found guilty.

Nair, though, is focused on the "sheer resilience [of the Krishnamoorthys] in the face of a [judicial] system designed to make you back down" and navigating a question like "the difference between revenge and justice". It's why he took a fictional and not a documentary route. "What I found incredible was the human aspect of it all—what it takes out of someone when you have to rely on the courts and how long they had to fight and struggle. They are an inspiration."

The book was fairly comprehensive, but Nair complemented it with over three months of research so as to have "a balanced, nuanced narrative". The Krishnamoorthys, with their deep knowledge of the event and the cases across different courts, were always accessible to Nair and his team. The filmmaker was especially grateful for "the space" the family afforded to tell the story he felt he needed to tell. Adds Nair, "You immediately feel the weight when you are telling someone's story, but you want to allow the audience to come to their own conclusion about what went wrong and why certain people are guilty." It justifies Nair's decision not to have his actors meet the Krishnamoorthys before or during the shoot. "Trying to emulate someone physically can become a crutch," says Nair. "Most important is to have the audience believe in the difficult moments and connect emotionally." For Abhay Deol, the fact that he didn't have to "inhabit or ape" someone's mannerisms enabled him to freely interpret the character and also depict the many ways grief manifests after an unimaginable loss. "It isn't just crying, it is tough to console someone," he says. "Goddamn, it is hard to stay in this zone. You can't prepare or rehearse for something like this."

Trial By Fire focuses on the sheer resilience of Neelam and Shekhar Krishnamoorthy, who lost their son and daughter in the tragedy

It was hard for Nair, too, who became a parent during the making of the show. "It wasn't the easiest thing to bring home every day." Settled in a tiny village on an island in Spain with his wife and two daughters, he is now looking forward to doing something "lighter". He's certain, though, that it'll be in the web series space. "I feel we have just scratched the surface with the format and to have that large a canvas is exciting." ■

Suhani Singh

Indian Films at IFFR



Which Colour?

Shahrukhkhan Chavada describes his directorial debut as one that reflects his "fascination with routine and highlights it as a visual language to weave" the story. Shot in black and white, the film follows a family in a Muslim quarter in Ahmedabad.

A Knock on the Door

In this psychological thriller, two professors (Adil Hussain and Amrita Chattopadhyay) find unwanted visitors who claim they are from a central intelligence agency. Directed by cinematographer Ranjan Palit, it features Naseeruddin Shah and Ratna Pathak Shah.





Follower

Harshad Nalawade's film follows a journalist who blindly believes in a cause propagated by a local leader in the territorially disputed hometown of Belagavi in Karnataka.